



Dream run: R. Praggnanandhaa (left) beat top guns like Alireza Firouzja, Magnus Carlsen (right), D. Gukesh and Vincent Keymer in succession to win the title. MICHAL WALUSZA/FIDE

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He has been around for so long that one hardly realises that he is just 20. From a prodigiously talented boy to a world-beater, R. Praggnanandhaa's journey has seen several ups and downs, but he has shown the ability to rise from tough times.

The Chennai-born GM was the toast of chess lovers in Oslo as he raised his game in stunning fashion to win four matches on the bounce and take the title at Norway Chess 2026. It is not often that one wins a tournament featuring Magnus Carlsen (**right**), that too in his own backyard.

Praggnanandhaa was over the

moon after the memorable triumph, the first ever by an Indian in Norway Chess, and said it was special.

"I think this is the biggest win of my career... also stronger in terms of average rating, I think, because you have some 2600s (rating) in Wijk Aan Zee (Tata Steel Chess Tournament). But here it's just the top players," he said after beating Germany's rising star Vincent Keymer in the 10th and final round to storm to the top spot, leapfrogging American Wesley So, who had appeared poised to seal the championship.

"Winning this is more special and Magnus was there" — a remark that shows why Praggnanandhaa rates the performance so highly.

To beat Carlsen once is considered huge in the sport; to do so twice — in the same tournament — is the stuff of legend. Praggnanandhaa did just that, outwitting the World No. 1 in

